

St. Joseph the All-Comely Orthodox Texas Prison Ministry Newsletter

Number 13, March 11/24 2021

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http://www.orthodox.net/prison-ministry/newsletter-013_2021-03-24+great-lent+precious-cross.pdf

Note: With God helping us, we will send many newsletters to all those we minister to in prison. We aim to send a newsletter at least twice each month. This is the 13th sent to 80 souls. Those who wish to contribute to our material needs in our ministry to Orthodox Christians may help us with donations at <http://www.orthodox.net/ministries/orthodox-prison-ministry.html>

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NOTE: Fr. David manages our ministry's distribution of Orthodox books, church calendars, icons, and service texts. Contact him if you need anything.

Questions about the Sunday of the Cross

Don't cheat! Try to answer the questions. Some of the articles in the newsletter may help you. The answers are at the end. No peeking!

1. How was the cross foreshadowed in the Old Testament? Give three examples

2. How did Jesus prophesy His death on a cross? Who did He tell he would die on a cross?

3. When was crucifixion used as a punishment?

4. Who remained near the cross from among His followers?

5. Normally Christians do not prostrate themselves on Sunday. Why? What is a prostration? On the Sunday of the Holy Cross, we do prostrate. Why and when?

6. Why do Christians make the sign of the cross? How is it made?

7. Where, when, how, and by whom was the true cross discovered?

8. How and when is the cross commemorated in the average week?

9. What major commemorations of the cross occur throughout the year?

10. How does one venerate the cross at the matins service? How would one person venerate the cross? How should two people venerate the cross (this is done to save a little time when there are many faithful)?

11. When a person makes the sign of the cross over himself, he arranges his fingers in a certain way, holding the thumb and first two fingers together at their tips, and folding the 4th and little finger down into the palm of the hand. What does this mean? When the priest blesses, he holds the fingers of his right hand a certain way to spell out four letters as an acronym. What do these letters represent?



A Primer for the Christian Beginning to Lead a Spiritual Life – 46-50

50. Love the Church's ordinances and strive to fulfill all of them. (*As a Brother Priest that forwarded these teachings to me always says: "Do not make a Greek salad out of them: keep some, neglect others. The Church is not a salad bar.."*)

51. Keep diligent watch over yourself, especially over your senses, through which the adversary gains access to your soul.

52. When confronted by your infirmity, by your weakness in accomplishing good deeds, remember that you cannot save yourself. Your Savior is our Lord Jesus Christ.

53. The cruel foe never slumbers. He stalks you throughout the day. Let faith be your impregnable fortress.

54. Sorrows, difficulties, illnesses – all these bring us closer to God; therefore, do not complain about them and do not fear them.

55. No one has ever reached Heaven by a life of pleasure and unbroken happiness.

Prison Ministry News

The most important news that affects us is that the prisons have opened up a little bit. Fr David has already gone to the Luther unit once. There are many restrictions, and we won't be able to celebrate the Liturgy and other things, but at least you will see us, or at least you will be able to see our eyes since they require us to look like Darth Vader when we come in. You must help us to see you. Every human being that we are writing to should send an I-60 asking for Orthodox Christian volunteers to be allowed

in. Tell them both of our names (Fr Holland and Fr Companik) and that one of us will be contacting them. Remember the parable about the unjust judge. The widow kept coming to him, and he didn't care about her at all, but because she kept asking, he gave her what she wanted. You be the widow, and I don't think you have to use your imagination too much to think about the unjust judge is in this parable!

We have some obstacles that we must overcome, and perhaps a flood of thy 60s will help us. According to Texas's courts, we are considered to be the redheaded stepchildren of Roman Catholics. They think of us as Roman Catholics, and officially they say that an Orthodox Christian asking for ministry services can go to the Roman Catholic services. We tell you that you should not! With God's help, we will be able to start seeing you again. You must do your part and send the I 60s. Please send the mail to one of us to tell us that you have sent the I 60.

From Fr David: Here's the current rundown on unit visits:

Luther - First and Third Saturdays, 11 AM (I'll go on First, other volunteers from Fr. Cassian's parish on Third)

Wynne - First and Third Mondays, 2:30 PM

Estelle - Currently on lockdown. Chaplain asked me to call back next week. I hope to go same days as Wynne.

Michael - Chaplain said they are only running primary services/programs to monitor COVID case count. Asked me to call back in April to see if secondary services can be scheduled. I'll aim for a First or Third Wednesday at Michael, or Friday as a backup.

I'm striving to leave Second and Fourth weeks free for taking care of correspondence, shipping books, and occasional pastoral visits that require a long drive.

Questions and Answers



How to read thoughts for each day of the year.

Many of you have this book, and there was a question about using it because it gets confusing at various times. This book will be easy to use during Great Lent. The Lenten Cycle begins on page 38 with the Sunday of the Publican and the Pharisee. You may read each day in order through the four weeks before Great Lent, all of Great Lent (begin pg 54), Lazarus Saturday and Palm Sunday (start pg 79), Holy week (begin pg 80), Pascha (pg 84), Bright week (begin pg 84), and all of the other weeks of the Paschal cycle beginning with Thomas Sunday until Pentecost (start 88, end pg 118).

When St. Theophan wrote this book, he was writing for a particular year. Therefore, there are feasts that he wrote about that will not necessarily be in the spot in which he mentions them. These are fixed-date feasts, such as the Annunciation, which is March 25 on the church calendar.

Don't be confused by this. Just make a note on the front cover where these feasts are in the book.

For example, in the year in which Bishop Theophan wrote this book, Annunciation fell on Great Thursday, and he comments about it there (pg 82). This year, it falls on March 25 (church date)/ April 7th (civil date), the 4th Wednesday of Great Lent.

Bright Monday begins on page 84, and you may read all the weeks of Bright week (6 full weeks) up till Pentecost and the Sundays after Pentecost through the 29th Sunday after Pentecost, with Monday through Friday Saturday following, until page 282.

After Pentecost, you can follow the book as he goes through the weeks after Pentecost (starting on pg 118)

Near the end of the year, before the Nativity fast, the readings get very confusing. Bishop Theophan's book will not match the calendar for those weeks. I would advise you to follow his book and read the readings that he specifies. It would take up take a lot of explaining to explain why this is the case, and it's confusing even for people who know the typicon very well.

By the Waters of Babylon. The Great Fast, Our Exile by Fr. Seraphim (Rose) March 1965

This weekend, at the Sunday Vigil of the Prodigal Son, we will sing Psalm 135.¹ **"By the rivers of Babylon, there we sat down, yea, we wept, when we remembered Zion."**

In these words of the Lenten Psalm, we Orthodox Christians, the New Israel, remember that we are in exile. For Orthodox Russians, banished from Holy Russia,² the Psalm has a special meaning; but all Orthodox Christians, too, live in exile in this world, longing to return to our true home, Heaven.

For us, the Great Fast is a session of exile ordained for us by our Mother, the Church, to keep fresh in us the memory of Zion from which we have wandered so far. We have deserved our exile, and we have great need of it because of our great sinfulness. Only through the chastisement of exile, which we remember in the fasting, prayer, and repentance of this season,

Do we remain mindful of our Zion? "If I forget thee, O Jerusalem..."

Weak and forgetful, even in the midst of the Great Fast, we live as though Jerusalem did not exist for us. We fall in love with the world, our Babylon; we are seduced by the frivolous pastimes of this "strange land" and neglect the services and discipline of the Church, which remind us of our true home. Worse yet, we love our very captors - for our sins hold us

captive more surely than any human master - and in their service, we pass in idleness the precious days of Lent when we should be preparing to meet the Rising Sun of the New Jerusalem, the Resurrection of our Lord Jesus Christ.

There is still time; we must remember our true home and weep over the sins which have exiled us from it. Let us take to heart the words of St. John of the Ladder: "Exile is separation from everything in order to keep the mind inseparable from God. An exile loves and produces continual weeping." Exiled from Paradise, we must become exiled from the world if we hope to return.

This we may do by spending these days in fasting, prayer, separation from the world, attendance at the services of the Church, in tears of repentance, in preparation for the joyful Feast that is to end this time of exile; and by bearing witness to all in this "strange land" of our remembrance of that even greater Feast that shall be when our Lord returns to take His people to the New Jerusalem, from which there shall be no more exile, for it is eternal.

This document is at:

<http://www.orthodox.net/greatlent/by-the-waters-of-babylon-the-great-fast-our-exile.html>

The First Week of Great Lent – Clean Monday. An Anthem for Great Lent and all of Life.

Wash yourselves, and ye shall be clean; put away the wicked ways from your souls before mine eyes; cease to do evil; 17. learn to do well; diligently seek judgment, relieve the oppressed, consider the fatherless, and plead for the widow. 18. Come then, and let us reason together, saith the Lord: and though your sins be as scarlet, I will make them white as snow; and though they red like crimson, I will make them white as wool. 19. If then ye be willing, and obedient unto Me, ye shall eat the good of the land; 20. but if ye desire not, nor will obey me, the sword shall devour you, for the mouth of the Lord has spoken it. (Is 1:1-20, First Monday of Great Lent, the Sixth Hour)

Everyone needs to wash frequently. The accumulated grime of the day is unsightly, unpleasant, and unhealthy. If we wash carefully and ignore no dirty place, we will be invigorated and healthy, but if we ignore some place for a long time, that place will fester and cause us to be ill.

Great Lent is especially a time for careful washing. In us, there may be wicked ways: thoughts, feelings, priorities, and habits that are not immediately apparent and are all displeasing to God.

This time is a time to consciously attempt to put away wicked ways from ourselves just as we put away from ourselves certain foods. How to do this? By listening and seeking, with diligence and proper priorities. This will lead to actions accomplished with a merciful heart, that is:

“learn to do well; diligently seek judgment, relieve the oppressed, consider the fatherless, and plead for the widow.”

Why should we make all this effort? Because some stains are so dark and embedded that we cannot of our own effort wash them out, and their ugliness and stench will always be with us, but if the Lord sees our resolve and effort, He will wash us so that the scarlet and crimson of our sins, and even of our sinful nature and predilections will be annihilated and forgotten, and will not return to infect us again.

18 “Come now, and let us reason together, saith the LORD: though your sins be as scarlet, they shall be as white as snow; though they be red like crimson, they shall be as wool.”

And those who struggle, with an honest and good heart, will inherit the good of the land, and know the Lord.

SIXTH HOUR – Clean Monday Isaiah 1:1-20 1 The vision of Isaiah the son of Amoz, which he saw concerning Judah and Jerusalem in the days of

Uzziah, Jotham, Ahaz, and Hezekiah, kings of Judah. 2 Hear, O heavens, and give ear, O earth: for the LORD hath spoken, I have nourished and brought up children, and they have rebelled against me. 3 The ox knoweth his owner, and the ass his master's crib: but Israel doth not know, my people doth not consider. 4 Ah sinful nation, a people laden with iniquity, a seed of evildoers, children that are corrupters: they have forsaken the LORD, they have provoked the Holy One of Israel unto anger, they are gone away backward. 5 Why should ye be stricken any more? ye will revolt more and more: the whole head is sick, and the whole heart faint. 6 From the sole of the foot even unto the head there is no soundness in it; but wounds, and bruises, and putrifying sores: they have not been closed, neither bound up, neither mollified with ointment. 7 Your country is desolate, your cities are burned with fire: your land, strangers devour it in your presence, and it is desolate, as overthrown by strangers. 8 And the daughter of Zion is left as a cottage in a vineyard, as a lodge in a garden of cucumbers, as a besieged city. 9 Except the LORD of hosts had left unto us a very small remnant, we should have been as Sodom, and we should have been like unto Gomorrah. 10 Hear the word of the LORD, ye rulers of Sodom; give ear unto the law of our God, ye people of Gomorrah. 11 To what purpose is the multitude of your sacrifices unto me? saith the LORD: I am full of the burnt offerings of rams, and the fat of fed beasts; and I delight not in the blood of bullocks, or of lambs, or of he goats. 12 When ye come to appear before me, who hath required this at your hand, to tread my courts? 13 Bring no more vain oblations; incense is an abomination unto me; the new moons and sabbaths, the calling of assemblies, I cannot away with; it is iniquity, even the solemn meeting. 14 Your new moons and your appointed feasts my soul hateth: they are a trouble unto me; I am weary to bear them. 15 And when ye spread forth your hands, I will hide mine eyes from you: yea, when ye make many prayers, I will not hear: your hands are full of blood. 16 Wash you, make you clean; put away the evil of your doings from before mine eyes; cease to do evil; 17 Learn to do well; seek judgment, relieve the oppressed, judge the fatherless, plead for the widow. 18 Come now, and let us reason together, saith the LORD: though your sins be as scarlet, they shall be as white as snow; though they be red like crimson, they shall be as wool. 19 If ye be willing and obedient, ye shall eat the good of the land: 20 But if ye refuse and rebel, ye shall be devoured with the sword: for the mouth of the LORD hath spoken it.

Priest Seraphim

<http://www.orthodox.net/greatlent/great-lent-01-01-clean-monday-sixth-hour-meditation.doc>

What are we strangers to?

For we are strangers on the earth, as were all our fathers; keep our short life without sin, O our Savior, and have mercy on us, as the lover of mankind. The Troparion of the Prophecy, 1st Tone: Clean Tuesday, the 6th hour.

This Troparion would be an excellent prayer any time of the year. It could be added to the morning rule or evening prayer for that matter; it could be sung or chanted. There are gems like this in all of our services. Read the services and the things that touch your heart; copy them out.

Are we strangers on the earth? Of course, this is a reference to Moses being a Stranger in a strange land when he was in the land of Midian, exiled from his people. During that 40 years in Midian, Moses grew in wisdom and holiness. That time prepared him to be a type of Christ, a savior of his people.

Which kind of stranger are we? Are we a stranger to the world or a stranger to holy things? The Troparion should make us ask this question.

A stranger feels unfamiliar with his surroundings or the people or the things around him. Are we unfamiliar with our surroundings? Or do we know the world all too well? When we are in the services, do we understand them, or do they feel unfamiliar? Perhaps they feel too long, or we don't understand specific phrases. Maybe we are not moved to compunction when we hear the words. Maybe the things that are being said and especially the exploits of the saints that are being lauded seem almost unreal

Shouldn't we, with humility, say that we are familiar with the world but strangers to holiness? Of course, in the spiritual life, everything is on a continuum. We are strangers to some sins, and we are familiar (because of experience) with some holy things. But if we examine ourselves carefully, we would see that we indeed are not strangers to everything evil. We know too much about evil because we have experienced it internally. And we know very little about holiness because we have not experienced God internally as those who are holy experience Him.

Wouldn't the beginning of our becoming familiar with God be that we admit to Him that we are strangers to Him in many areas of our life? And wouldn't it also be appropriate for us, as we confess to Him that we are strangers to Him in such things as humility, and chastity, self-control, and unceasing prayer, we would also beg Him with compunction that we would be strangers to at least some things of the world?

The First Week of Great Lent – Clean Friday THE ONLY SOLUTION FOR OUR UNREPENTANT HEARTS

"Our greatly sinful life and unrepentant disposition do thou forestall through thy compassion, O Lord; beside Thee we know none other, O thou that has dominion over life and death: save us, as thou art the lover of mankind." (Friday in the First Week - At the Sixth Hour, the Troparion of the Prophecy, 5th Tone)

Do you wonder how you are ever going to get better? Do you ever have doubts because you tend to fall into the same foolish sins day after day? Do you wonder if you ever REALLY repent?

If you have these feelings, then you are thinking correctly, but without sure knowledge that the Lord will save those whom He loves and that the resurrection will make you capable of total change, you will fall into despair.

Let's face it, we are bad. We are lazy, and forgetful, and insincere. We mean something one minute and contradict ourselves by our actions the next.

And as we beg the Lord to help us be strangers to the world, we must be aware that the enemy keeps us from knowing God (and therefore, being strangers to the world) is sin. And we know that we sin. Sin blackens us, and darkens our thoughts, and confuses us. So we should beg the Lord to help keep us without sin.

Of course, just asking this is not a magical incantation. We ask it over and over, and just as often as we ask it, we must act upon our request by struggling against sin, and the grace of God fills us, and eventually, sin is demolished, it is shattered, and it is as far away from us as the East is from the West.

<http://www.orthodox.net/greatlent/great-lent-01-02-clean-wednesday-sixth-hour-troparion.pdf>
<http://www.orthodox.net/greatlent/great-lent-01-02-clean-wednesday-sixth-hour-troparion.doc>

What is the only solution for us? The abyss of God's mercy. Remember, mercy is not only that God will not punish us if we repent. If this was all, we would all fall into the pit since we are not truly repentant. God's mercy will help us to repent. This change does not occur right away, but only with arduous labor, coupled with God's grace.

Let us fall before the abyss of God's mercy and beg him to "forestall" our unrepentant heart, that is, to help us change it to a repentant one, and to gain peace and knowledge, and wisdom and purity. This is our only chance, and we must be confident of this very thing, that He Who has begun a good work in us will complete it.

<http://www.orthodox.net/greatlent/great-lent-01-05-clean-friday-sixth-hour-meditation.doc>

With the fire of abstinence... 3rd Week of Great Lent – Monday Matins.

With the fire of abstinence let us all burn up the thorns of the passions that assault us, and with streams of tears let us put out the flame that shall never be quenched; and let us cry aloud to Him Who shall come to judge the whole earth: O Savior and all-merciful Lord, guard us uncondemned and grant us the forgiveness of our sins. Great Lent, the Third Week, Monday, Matins Sessional Hymn, Tone 8

Our services contain numerous exhortations and explanations about how to live the way of life; their poetry, especially when they are sung, touching the soul in sublime ways.

This hymn is an amazing example of one of the favorite poetical themes of our hymns – juxtaposing opposites by taking some aspect of scripture and looking at it from a different perspective which is useful for our instruction and edification.

We sing a request for fire to *BURN UP* our passions. One does not usually think of fire in this way.

In scripture, fire is often used to allude to strong, "hot" passions, such as anger, hate, lust, and all passions of the flesh which burn within us. For instance, when the man with the demoniac boy described the pitiful state of his son, he said:

"Lord, have mercy on my son: for he is epileptic, and suffereth grievously; for oft-times he falleth into the fire, and off-times into the water." (Mat 17:15)

The fire represents these "hot sins" and the water "worldly sins" such as acquisitiveness, distractions, and vanity.

St Andrew of Crete vividly describes fiery sins in his Great Canon, when he refers to Esau as Edom (which is translated "red"):

"Esau was called Edom for his extreme passion of madness for women. For ever burning with incontinence and stained with pleasures, he was named Edom which means a red-hot sin-loving soul." (Great Canon, Tuesday, Ode 4)

Abstinence is not generally thought of as a "fire" but rather as something which cools it and starves it. After our Lord healed the demoniac boy, his disciples asked why they could not expel the demon. His answer is a primary reason why we fast:

Then came the disciples to Jesus apart, and said, Why could not we cast it out? (20) And he saith unto them, Because of your little faith: for verily I say unto you, If ye have faith as a grain of mustard seed, ye shall say unto this mountain, Remove hence to yonder place; and it shall remove; and nothing shall be impossible unto you. (21) **But this kind goeth not out save by prayer and fasting.** (Mat 17:19-21)

This hymn looks at fire in a wholly different way, but not without precedent. Here, abstinence is referred to with the same vehemence as we would describe "hot" sins, which often overpower the soul with their hot ferocity. Here abstinence is overpowering fire!

How can such a thing be? **Only if we fast with *desire*.** When the soul is aflame with fiery sins, it is taken away and thinks of nothing else when the flame is burning. So it should be with our fasting.

If we fast haphazardly, occasionally, with numerous "*exemptions*" due to "*circumstances*," then we are not burning our sins with fasting. We fool ourselves. If fasting can burn out fire, it must be even hotter than fire; if we fast inconsistently or without firm resolution, then our fasting is only lukewarm, and lukewarmness is good for nothing in the spiritual life and even causes our condemnation.

"So because thou art lukewarm, and neither hot nor cold, I will spew thee out of my mouth." (Rev 3:16)

This hymn calls the passions "thorns"; no thorn is part of the vine of Christ. In the end, that which does not abide in Christ will be burned:

"If a man abide not in me, he is cast forth as a branch, and is withered; and they gather them, and cast them into the fire, and they are burned." (John 15:6)

Brothers and sisters! With our fasting, we have the opportunity to burn our passions before they burn us! If our abstinence is as fire, *we are fulfilling the scripture*:

"If any man's work shall be burned, he shall suffer loss: but he himself shall be saved; yet so as through fire."

(1Corinthians 3:15)

Let us pass through the fire now, at a time of our own choosing! Our abstinence is difficult, and indeed, we suffer loss, but with this loss, we burn away our passions, so that in the end, we will not be burned.

http://www.orthodox.net/dailylent/great-lent-week-03-monday_2009+matins+with-the-fire-of-abstinence.html

"The Ensign of the people..."

Sixth Hour, Isaiah 11:10-12:2 3rd Week of Great Lent – Thursday

In that day the root of Jesse, who standeth for an ensign of the people, him the Gentiles shall beseech, and his sepulchre shall be glorious. Great Lent, the Third Week, Thursday, The Sixth Hour, Isaiah 11:10, from the selection: Isaiah 11:10-12:2

The "**root of Jesse**" is none other than our Lord Jesus Christ, who came from the line of Jesse.

"**Ensign**" can also be rendered "standard," and this is a foreshadowing of the precious cross. The cross is our ensign; we venerate it because of our Lord's accomplishments upon it, and we look to it to teach us the "way of the cross," that is, imitating the moral life of our Savior.

"His sepulcher shall be glorious" is a prophecy regarding our Lord's tomb – it indeed would be glorious when He rose from the dead in it.

http://www.orthodox.net/dailylent/great-lent-week-03-thursday_2009+sixth-hour+the-ensign-of-the-people.html

Wisdom has built a house for herself, and set up seven pillars

3rd Week of Great Lent – TUESDAY. Vespers.

Wisdom has built a house for herself, and set up seven pillars. 2. She has killed her beasts; she has mingled her wine in a bowl, and prepared her table. 3. She has sent forth her servants, calling with a loud proclamation to the feast, saying, 4. Who so is foolish, let him turn aside to me: and to them that want understanding she says, 5. Come, eat of my bread, and drink wine which I have mingled for you. 6. Leave folly, that ye may reign for ever; and seek wisdom, and improve understanding by knowledge. Tuesday in the Third Week of Great Lent- At Vespers - Proverbs 9:1-6, from the selection Prov 8:32 - 9:11

St Hippolytus of Rome, On Proverbs

Christ, he means, the wisdom and power of God the Father, hath builded His house, i.e., His nature in the flesh derived from the Virgin, even as he (John) hath said beforetime, "The Word became flesh, and dwelt among us." As likewise the wise prophet testifies: Wisdom that was before the world, and is the source of life, the infinite "Wisdom of God, hath builded her house" by a mother who knew no man, -- to wit, as He assumed the temple of the body.

"And hath raised her seven pillars;" that is, the fragrant grace of the all-holy Spirit, as Isaiah says: "And the seven spirits of God shall rest upon Him," But others say that the seven pillars are the seven divine orders which sustain the creation by His holy and inspired teaching; to wit, me prophets, the apostles, the martyrs, the hierarchs, the hermits, the saints, and the righteous.

And the phrase, "She hath killed her beasts," denotes the prophets and martyrs who in every city and country are slain like sheep every day by the unbelieving, in behalf of the truth, and cry aloud, "For thy sake we are killed all the day long, we were counted as sheep for the slaughter."

And again, "She hath mingled her wine" in the bowl, by which is meant, that the Savior, uniting his Godhead, like pure wine, with the flesh in the Virgin, was born of her at once God and man without confusion of the one in the other.

"And she hath furnished her table:" that denotes the promised knowledge of the Holy Trinity; it also refers to His honored and undefiled body and blood, which day by day are administered and offered sacrificially at the spiritual divine table, as a memorial of that first and ever-memorable table of the spiritual divine supper.

And again, "She hath sent forth her servants:" Wisdom, that is to say, has done so-- Christ, to wit -- summoning them with lofty announcement.

"Whoso is simple, Let him turn to me," she says, alluding manifestly to the holy apostles, who traversed the whole world, and called the nations to the knowledge of Him in truth, with their lofty and divine preaching.

And again, "And to those that want understanding she said"-- that is, to those who have not yet obtained the power of the Holy Ghost -- "Come, eat of my bread, and drink of the wine which I have mingled for you;" by which is meant, that He gave His divine flesh and honored blood to us, to eat and to drink it for the remission of sins.

http://www.orthodox.net/dailylent/great-lent-week-03-tuesday_2009+vespers+wisdom-has-built-a-house-for-herself.html

"Joyful celebration of the fast". WHY follow the commandments? Because we will change. Orthodox Math

3rd Week of Great Lent – Wednesday Matins

“As we continue in the joyful celebration of the fast, we cry aloud: keep us all in peace, O Lord, deliver us from every snare of the enemy, and in Thy surpassing love count us worthy to venerate with love Thy precious cross, through which thou grantest to the inhabited world Thy mercy, O Thou who alone art most merciful.” Great Lent, the Third Week, Wednesday, The Sixth Hour, Sessional Hymn, Tone Two (by Theodore)

The services are enthusiastic! I love to hear their enthusiasm about the living of the spiritual life, and their frequent enraptured meditation on the truths and dogmas of our faith. I hope you do too.

This hymn is one of many during the Great Fast that count this “tithe”³ of the year as great blessing and joy.

This attitude is a different perspective for some of us. For some, Great Lent is a time to “give up” things, and deal with inconvenience and difficulty in planning meals.

The reason for these feelings is a serious misunderstanding of the Fast, and also the main reason for the Fast, the following of the commandments.

The Fast is not IMPOSED upon us, nor are any of the sweet commandments of the Lord imposed upon us. We follow the commandments because they are the only way of life and because we will be changed and perfected.

Does anybody want to stay the same way they are right now? Do you still wish to have bouts of laziness, depression, shame because of your behavior and intrusive thoughts that make you feel dark and cold? If you

like this state, you may have it forever, and you need not do anything to achieve it!

If a person wants to change, the Fast is a joyful time, because it facilitates change. We will not always be in our current, wretched condition; we will be changed.

The joyful faster always has that “blessed hope”⁴ within him when he fasts. The fast may truly have great difficulties and sorrows for us, but the Christian is joyful, even in his sorrow, because he knows that he is getting better. Most of the time, we cannot “feel” that we are getting better; we will believe this only as we continue to struggle and God sends us ineffable consolation.

To those who consider the phrase “joyful fast” and oxymoron, the church hymns constantly invite: “Come and see!”⁵

http://www.orthodox.net/dailylent/great-lent-week-03-wednesday_2009+sixth-hour+sessional-hymn,-joyful-celebration.html

"A deceitful balance" - Proverbs 10:31-11:12

3rd Week of Great Lent – FRIDAY Vespers

A deceitful balance is an abomination before the Lord: and a just weight is his will. Great Lent, the Third Week, Friday, Vespers – Proverbs 11:1, from the selection: Proverbs 10:31-11:12

The Proverbs are excellent texts for checking ourselves. We must read the scriptures with the intent of finding personal correction and guidance.

When we observe good or bad behavior, do we resemble it? When there is a rebuke, would we deserve the same? When a prayer is uttered or a promise made, would we be truth-tellers or liars if we said the same thing?

Here we are told something about honesty. In old times, the product was weighed on a balance and sold by weight. An unscrupulous merchant could add weight to the side on which he weighed the product so that a small amount would seem heavier, or he could label the weights that he added to the other side incorrectly by overstating their weight. In either case, the result was (for instance) that a customer would think he was buying a pound, but in reality the weight would only be twelve ounces.

The way we judge things and present ourselves to others may be considered a “balance .”

Our balance is deceitful if we prefer one person over another because of their wealth, or position or notoriety, as the Holy Brother of the Lord tells us:

“My brethren, have not the faith of our Lord Jesus Christ, the Lord of glory, with respect of persons. (2) For if there come unto your assembly a man with a gold ring, in goodly apparel, and there come in also a poor man in vile raiment; (3) And ye have respect to him that weareth the gay clothing, and say unto him, Sit thou here in a good place; and say to the poor, Stand thou there, or sit here under my footstool: (4) Are ye not then partial in yourselves, and are become judges of evil thoughts?” (James 2:1-4 KJV)

We have a deceitful balance if we speak ill of another behind their back. Our balance is false if we are more likely to talk or listen to someone if they are pretty, or interesting. Is not our balance deceitful when we promise to do something and do not do it?

Anytime that we hide dark thoughts in our hearts regarding our brethren, regardless of whether we think that we act upon them, we carry within us a deceitful balance.

http://www.orthodox.net/dailylent/great-lent-week-03-friday_2009+deceitful-balance.html

Explanation of the Veneration of the Cross, and “Before Thy Cross”

The Sunday of the Veneration of the Holy and Precious Cross



Prostrating before our Old Rugged Cross⁶

On the Third Sunday of Great Lent, we commemorate the veneration of the Holy and Precious Cross. There are six Sundays in Great Lent, and then comes Holy Week. This day was chosen because it is in the middle of Great Lent. The cross is also called the “Tree of Life.” Capitalism first capitalism of Life was planted in the middle of the garden of Eden, so it is appropriate to venerate the holy and precious Cross in the middle of the Great Fast.

After the sin of Adam and Eve, the tree of life was guarded by a cherubim with a flaming sword, but the second Tree of Life is not guarded; it actually is presented to us to teach us the only way that leads to life.

We are preparing to celebrate the resurrection (Pascha), but before the resurrection was the Cross, so it is wholly appropriate in the middle of the fast to remind ourselves about the Cross.

The cross is a symbol of life and also of struggle (since our Lord told us that if we will, we should take up the cross – this involves a great struggle till the end of our lives), so venerating it should also remind us that *Great Lent is a time of increased struggle*. All of our struggle has an end and a purpose – this is to have all of our passions and sins are expelled and united with God.

This could not happen without two things. The first is that our *Lord Jesus Christ followed the way of the cross*, that is, obedience to His Father and love. After the Cross, He descended into Hades and vanquished death, and made us able to live forever, giving us a way to be joined to the church through baptism, and sending the Holy Spirit to abide in us and help us to struggle against and eventually completely vanquish sin. The second is that we would obey that which the Lord told us to do if we are willing – “*take up our cross he*” and after our baptism, struggle with all of our might to achieve our purpose – union with God.

There are many things about the cross that the Scripture teaches and that resonate in our soul:

The Cross was formerly an instrument of death, and now of life.

We must take up the Cross and struggle for virtue, even though sometimes this is very hard to do.

We are unworthy because we are great sinners, yet God in His love has made us capable of eternal life.

We must crucify ourselves to the Cross just as our Lord Jesus Christ allowed Himself to be crucified.

Before Thy Cross we bow down and worship...

In the name of the Father, and the Son and the Holy Spirit, Amen.

I want to speak about “**Before Thy Cross**” and what it means. We cannot speak about the Cross without talking about the Resurrection, because the Cross was the gateway to the Resurrection. The Lord had to

All of these things and more resonate in the soul when we venerate the cross at the end of the matins service.

Matins is a morning service, often served before Liturgy, or in Russian practice, and on Mount Athos during long vigils, s

The Matins service commemorating the Holy Cross has an addition to it that is in no other matins service, the entire year. Near the end of the service, after singing many compunctionate hymns, we conclude the hymns with the “Great Doxology”⁷, just as we do in any festive Matins service. The addition to our worship then occurs at the end of the Doxology, when we sing repetitively and very slowly, just as in a funeral: “**Holy God, Holy Mighty, Holy Immortal have mercy on us .**” This should remind us that even though the Cross is a symbol of life for us, death had to occur and must *continue* to occur for us to have life. The first death was that of our Lord Jesus Christ and He shall never die again. The second death must be ours, and it must be a *continuous* death to our sins.

As this hymn is being sung very slowly, the priest is carrying a decorated Cross, usually on a platter with many flowers and/or basil leaves, an of the altar. He stops in front of the Royal Doors, and exclaims in a loud voice: “Wisdom, aright! .” Then he makes the sign of the Cross with the Cross he is holding and turns and goes to the middle of the church, to put the Cross on a stand for veneration. As he is walking we sing three times the Troparion of the Cross: “O Lord, save thy people”⁸

Then the priest and the clergy (only) sing the following hymn, loudly, and without haste: “**Before Thy Cross we bow down and worship O Master, and Thy Holy Resurrection We Glorify .**”

As the words “**we bow down**” are sung, everyone prostrates to the ground, as they are making the sign of the Cross upon themselves. As we begin to sing: “**And Thy holy Resurrection,**” we rise from the ground. In this way, we are reminded of death and burial, and the resurrection. This clearly shows how the Cross and the resurrection are linked. It is not possible to have one without the other.

After the clergy have sung, all the people sing together another three times, with more prostrations. This is a time when everyone should sing, whether they sing well or not, and they should sing loudly, not with haste, and with great feeling.

After this, everyone comes up to venerate the Cross, making prostrations before it, and being blessed by the priest, while other hymns are being sung.

It is impossible to put into words what the soul is feeling or should be feeling during these moments. The following words, spoken during a Vespers⁹ before the Matins in which the Cross was venerated are an attempt to do the impossible. The only way to really understand them is to worship through the long Matins service, and at the end of it to venerate the cross.

http://www.orthodox.net/catechism/orthopraxis_2018+explanation-of-veneration-of-the-cross-before-thy-cross-sunday-of-the-cross.html

die in order to go down to Hades and “destroy death by death” as we sing in the Paschal Troparion¹⁰, and then be risen again.

When we sing “Before Thy Cross,” we recall the death and the resurrection of Christ, and therefore the death and the resurrection of us. And so, on Sunday, we will prostrate. We usually don’t prostrate at any

Sunday of the year, except when the cross is celebrated on that day. There are only two possibilities - during Great Lent on the Third Sunday, and also the Exaltation of the Cross, which is celebrated in September and sometimes falls on a Sunday.

We sing: **“Before thy Cross, we bow down and worship O Master, and Thy Holy Resurrection we glorify.”**

With our bodies, we are showing what we believe. We go down, which is burial, which is death, and we surely get up, which is resurrection.

This is very meaningful, especially in the context of the long service¹¹, when we go out in the center of the church and everyone is before the Cross. We sing together this Troparion, and then many more stichera¹² about the cross.

The way of the Cross is not the way of death; it is the way of resurrection. It is the way of knowing which things dead and which things are alive. The temporary things of the world are dead: pride is dead, envy, jealousy – all the passions – they are all dead, they all lead to death. There is nothing meaningful in Them at all. The only thing that is meaningful, that is alive, is Jesus Christ. And if we are members of His body, then we also are alive.

The Cross is this beginning of our new life because the Lord said: “If I be lifted up, I will draw all men to myself”¹³. So, when you prostrate before the Cross tonight, remember that it is your resurrection which you are declaring, and thanking God for. If the Lord had not risen from the dead, it would not have mattered if He died on the Cross. If the Lord was not God and man, it would not matter if He died on the Cross. He had to be God and man, and He had to have His manhood (human nature) die and then take it up again, so that the power of death would be destroyed.

This is what we are recalling when we prostrate before the Cross.

Normally a prostration is penitential: it is often about our sins, such as when we do the “Prayer of St. Ephrem”¹⁴, or when we do other prostrations during the Holy Fast, during the various services. These prostrations are about repentance; we have feeling that we have done something wrong. I don’t mean something specific; I mean that there is something wrong with us, something not right.

But when we are prostrating tonight, it’s not this type of prostration. It is a prostration where we are, in a way, physically acting out death and then the resurrection. Of course, we don’t do dramatic reenactments in our worship in the Orthodox Church; let’s leave that for the people that are in the big churches that have auditoriums. We are living in the moment; we are in the resurrection now, are we not? The Lord said the Kingdom of Heaven is within you¹⁵, so that must mean we are in the resurrection now.

Now, as far as why there are so many things that go wrong with us, that’s a difficult question to answer. It’s a question we should strive to figure out. Why is it that, if we are in the resurrection, we continue to do such sinful things? So, I suppose, even while you are prostrating before the cross with great joy, there should be sort of wistfulness, a sadness, that although the Lord has granted you resurrection, you are not worth living worthily of it yet. But, if you desire to, you will. Gratitude is a powerful virtue because, with gratitude, we do everything we can for the One, to Whom we are grateful.

When we prostrate before the Lord today, before His Holy and Precious Cross, let us be grateful that He has given us the resurrection. This is not as an event to occur in the *future* but is a *state of being that is occurring now*. It’s not completed in us yet; we can prove that the next time we get mad or lazy or have some black thought. But which one of us would deny that it has begun? That would be a blasphemy. The resurrection is occurring in us right now, and that is what we are celebrating when we bow down before the cross.

“We bow down before thy Cross and Thy Holy Resurrection we glorify.” The two are one, two parts of the same thought. So, let us live in the resurrection, brothers and sisters!

“The blessing of the Lord be upon you through His grace and love for mankind, always now and ever and unto the ages of ages. Amen.”¹⁶

http://www.orthodox.net/catechism/orthopraxis_2018+explanation-of-veneration-of-the-cross-before-thy-cross-sunday-of-the-cross.html

Sunday of the Veneration of the Holy and Precious Cross

The cross tells us that Jesus Christ is born our infirmities and will heal us. We must bring our infirmities to him

In the name of the Father, and of the Son and the Holy Spirit, Amen¹⁷.

I read the letter of Divine Ascent every Great Lent. It’s a book by St. John Climacus – we commemorate him next week. I recommend it to everybody, except perhaps some of chapter 5 for some of you. It’s really a remarkable book. It has things like this in it that remind me very much about the cross.

“Let us who are weak and passionate have the courage to offer our infirmity and natural weakness to Christ with unhesitating faith and confess it to Him; and we shall be certain to obtain His help, even beyond our merit, if only we unceasingly go right down to the depth of humility.”¹⁸

I was thinking about what he said and how little we do this. Yes, we say things like “Lord have mercy,” and we say our prayers, not from the depth of our heart say to God:

“I’m weak, and I can’t get it done.”

“I don’t love my neighbor and my enemy.”

“I don’t know how to always have good thoughts in my head.”

“I don’t know how to stop doing this and start doing that.”

“I’m kind of a mess.”

That’s what this teaching by St. John reminds me of that we should have this idea in our heart that: “I can’t do it” and offer our infirmity to God. This is what today’s feast is about.

It’s not about this idea that people have that there was some sort of sacrifice that Jesus made to his Father (that was necessitated by God’s nature). The reason that our Lord was on the cross was in order to cleanse us and heal us. It was to drive a stake – the Canon talks about that – into

Hades, to break it. The reason that He did this is because He fully feels our infirmities.

I'm not even sure we really feel our infirmities. Actually, I'm positive that we don't. A lot of what we feel, such as unhappiness or dissatisfaction – is really our own brokenness, the fact that we have these infirmities that only God can heal. And He is the high priest that knows our infirmities. The Epistle of today talks about that. He "was in all points tempted like as we are"¹⁹, except that He was without sin. He knows what it's like to be a human being that is corrupt and incomplete. He took that corrupt human flesh and made it incorrupt. He understands, He remembers. Therefore, He is someone we can go to and say: "I'm broken." You can say things to Jesus Christ that you wouldn't dare say to another person. You have to learn to be able to say those things to Jesus Christ, because He identifies with your infirmities.

The cross is always associated with the resurrection. We don't speak of the cross without speaking of the resurrection. Every Sunday matins has a canon that is entitled "To the Cross and Resurrection." So, when you look upon the cross, it is no longer an instrument of death but an instrument of victory. It was God's way, after He became man, to have His human flesh die (which is what happens to human flesh, including His) and go down into Hades and break that connection between sin and death. He died just as human flesh died, but He did not have any sin, so there was no hook – the father's talk about a hook – there was no hook to Christ, so the devil could not hold onto Him, because there was no sin, whereas we die and we have sin and the devil can have a hold on us.

Christ died to break that hold, and yet we see evidence of that hold in our life. We see brokenness in our life.

I hope you see brokenness in your life, and not in a way that is destructive. So much of our feelings about our brokenness are destructive – addiction, depression, bad self-esteem, anxiety - all that sort of stuff – all these afflictions that seem to be everywhere in our modern society, which does not seem to know how to live. You should feel broken but not broken in that way, because that's just destructive. Instead, you should say to the Lord: "I have these infirmities and I know You bore my infirmities; you can help me – You're the only one Who can."

I hope that, over time, your prayer much more intimate, where it's not just a recitation of things, but at your heart saying: "God help me, You're my life, there is no life without Thee."

That's what the cross is saying to me, every day. We should wear it upon our breast and make the sign of the cross when we do things, because without the cross there would not have been His death. Without the death of Christ, He would not have gone down in the Hades and He would not have broken that connection between sin and death. And He would not have given us the capability to defeat sin and to defeat death.

And yet, we are broken, and we have infirmities. So, we must go to the One who bore our infirmities. He was in all points tempted like us yet without sin.

Paul goes on to say: "Let us therefore come boldly unto the throne of grace, that we may obtain mercy, and find grace to help in time of need."²⁰ That's also what St. John's advice is: "Let us who are weak and passionate have the courage to offer our infirmity and natural weakness to Christ with unhesitating faith." They are the same exact idea, one from the apostle, and the other one from one who followed the Apostle, perhaps something like 700 years later.

Bring your infirmities before God. We are accustomed to hiding our infirmities, because we don't look too bad, but if we should go to God and say:

"I'm broken, I can't really figure out how to love this person, and how not to have bad thoughts about him."

"I can't really figure out how to stop having these unclean thoughts."

"I can't really figure how to stop being irritable and making people mad at me."

"I really can't figure out how to stop being lazy and say my prayers."

"I can't really figure out much of anything."

You bring that before God, and He knows what that's like because He bore the infirmities of the human race - all of them. He did not have them, for instance, He didn't have infirmity of being lazy, but He did bear our infirmities, and He knows and understands every single problem you have. This is because He is a human being. Now, He changed His humanity to be perfected, which is where our humanity is going. That's what the cross saying.

After Liturgy we are going out to our "Old Rugged Cross," as long as it's not raining, and prostrate before it as we normally do. And we will sing this hymn:

"Before thy Cross, we bow down and worship O master, and Thy Holy Resurrection we glorify."

The Most of the time when you make a prostration it is because of penitence. A prostration is because we are unworthy; it is because we say: "Lord help me," like we do for the prayer of St Ephrem. There is always this echo of penitence, because it's built on our memory – that is, if you do enough prostrations it's built in your memory – if you hardly ever do prostrations, you might not understand this. But if you do prostrations a lot, there's a certain sense of unworthiness, and also boldness.

Today, these prostrations are not because of penitence; it is remembering our infirmity and that He bore our infirmities, and we are going to get up! Sometimes some of us have a little trouble getting up, but we are all going to get up. The Lord will get us up. There is the resurrection. We can experience it to different degrees in this life - some of us a lot, some of us a little. Some of us have just too many troubles.

I hear so many troubles. I heard from somebody who has a lot of troubles last night. Those troubles are not going to go away for a long time, but this person is approaching them in the right way and putting their infirmities before God. Fortunately, there some resources that this person knows about and that I've also put them in contact with, and it's a long hard road, but God knows that road – He walked that road. That's what the epistle says, and this advice from St. John Climacus says. That's what the cross says, that you, the person who is messed up, can be healed completely.

That's what I hope is in your heart when you do these prostrations at the end of Liturgy. The resurrection is coming, and it is also happening. There is a future resurrection, when there is no sickness or sorrow or sighing anymore, and there is the resurrection working itself into us – now. There is still sickness, and sorrow, and sighing; there are still long days and long weeks and long years, and difficulties that might never ever get

rectified completely. But there is the resurrection happening in you now. I hope you have some consolation and feel that resurrection amid your infirmities, and you feel God helping you, and you feel confident that He will help you even though you are unworthy.

Just try, besides rattling off your prayers – sometimes try just saying to God: I'm broken, and I know that You know what being broken is like, and You can fix it." That's what I say to God when I prostrate before the cross. And every day, my days are a mixture of contrasts. There are wonderful, beautiful, and holy things that happen, and in the midst of it, there I am, and I am not wonderful or beautiful or holy. So, this sort of cognitive dissonance occurs all the time, and yet somehow things happen. I hope that is happening with you, too; I hope that you are seeing things happen in your life. I hope that no matter how dark it seems that you know that there is light.

There's no substitute really for work, you must do the work, but with the work, there is grace, there is God's grace helping you. That's what the

cross is telling you today. I hope it is telling you this; that's what I'm telling you that you should be hearing because I hear that resounding. Just try this. When you prostrate before the cross today, just think a little bit, see if you can break precedent, and remember the sermon. We don't remember things; it's hard to remember what somebody said five minutes after they said it. But let there be this be like an emblem in your heart that says: "I'm broken, and God knows what it's like to be broken, and He can fix me." So, I'm going down saying, "I'm broken," but I'm getting up because God can make me stand²¹. That's what the cross means. God bless you and help you.

http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/gl-sun-03_2018+a-high-priest-who-knows-our-infirmities_hebrews4-15-15-6.pdf

AUDIO: http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/gl-sun-03_2018+a-high-priest-who-knows-our-infirmities_hebrews4-15-15-6.mp3

What Shall a Man Give in Exchange for His Soul

3rd Sunday of Great Lent - Holy Cross

In the name of the Father and of the Son and the Holy Spirit. Amen.

Brothers and sisters, this is now the midpoint of the fast, the Sunday in which we exalt the All-Holy Cross, the third Sunday of Great Lent.

In this gospel that we read today, there are many important points, and there are important questions that you must answer. The essential question is this: What shall a man give in exchange for his soul? The question before it is: What shall it profit a man if he shall gain the whole world and lose his own soul? But that is sort of, more of a general question.

The question that follows it, what shall a man give in exchange for his own soul, applies to every moment of your life. It's not just a general theoretical question. These are not rhetorical questions.

In Christianity, and any discipline or belief, whether you want to become a doctor or a basketball player, you must make value judgments. You must decide what is essential and what is not important. If it's important to become a doctor, then you're going to study when you would otherwise want to watch TV or go out and party. If you were a Christian, you would pray when you don't feel like praying; you will fast when you don't feel like fasting; you will forgive when you don't feel like forgiving; you will struggle even when you don't feel like struggling. Why? Because this question should always be answered in your soul: **What shall a man give in exchange for his soul?**

What is worth your soul? What on earth, what can you possibly gain in this world that is worth your soul? There's nothing. The whole world is going away. Everything is temporary. Everything in the world is filled with vice and with some mixture of pride and hidden agendas and everything else. There's nothing pure in the world. There's nothing worth saving in the world, except those that become like Christ and are not of the world. So in your daily life, you should be answering this question **every single moment**.

The alarm clock rings and you're kind of sleepy and you don't want to get up, but if you don't get up and you wait for the snooze two or three times, or maybe you oversleep, then you have to hurry, throw on your clothes and run to work and you miss your prayers. *What kind of exchange was that?* Perhaps you'll forget about it, but you've lost something. You had an opportunity for grace, and you squandered it.

You're driving to work, and you see someone cut you off. And you want to be angry at that person, perhaps even curse at that person or gesture at them or say something nasty about them. But if you do that, you lose grace, and you lose peace. Your Holy Guardian Angel flees from you when you act in such a way. *Is that a good exchange?* - to exercise your self-righteous ego for a few moments?

You can answer this question in everything you do, in everything in your life. Everything is an exchange, everything.

In the Great Canon, Saint Andrew talks about being a good trader. We must be a trader, and our currency is our selves. We give of ourselves to God, and He gives us eternal life. And everything is a trade. Don't kid yourself. Everything you do has consequences. Every single thing you do and say and think is a trade, is an exchange. Either you do what is good, or you do what is bad. There's not any in-between. Either our thoughts are holy, or they're not.

Now, I know that our thoughts can be mixed with un-holiness. We can try to do a good thing and then feel proud about it. Don't worry about that; just do the good thing and then confess to God that you're proud. As for involuntary sins like feeling proud because you did a good thing - God will help you with those. But you must struggle to make your exchange in the **things that you can do**, such as fasting, prayer, attending the services, and praying at the services, not just being a "candle holder" at the services, but following them with attention. And all these things are an exchange for your soul.

It is apropos that on the Sunday of the Cross, this reading would be read. Of course, it's about the Cross, and it specifically mentions that we must take up our Cross. Fundamentally, if you do not take up your Cross, if you do not exchange that which is worthless for that which is beyond worth, then you cannot be saved.

We live in an age of self-indulgence. I think people were always self-indulgent, but they didn't have as much time or energy to be able to devote themselves to self-indulgence as we do now. With better help and technologies, we can entertain ourselves and indulge ourselves almost all day long. Even when we are ostensibly at work, we can indulge ourselves. In this age of self-indulgence, we don't know much about denying ourselves, and it seems to be against our modern creed to deny ourselves.

What does it mean to deny ourselves? **It means to make an exchange.** When the Lord said, "Whosoever will come after Me, let him deny himself and take up his cross and follow Me," He repeats the same thought in the question: "What shall a man give in exchange for his soul?" Because **denying yourself is denying things that are worthless, that have no permanence, that lead you away from God.** It means self-discipline; it means understanding what's important in life and going about obtaining it.

And we, worldwide, are mediocre as Christians because we don't understand what's essential; and when we do have some glimmer of it, we don't proceed after it with zeal. If we did, our churches would be full to overflowing, and our people would be full of grace and would attract other people to the faith.

Instead, we are sometimes almost like little enclaves because we are mediocre in our Christianity. That's not what God intended for us. He said, deny yourself, take up your cross and follow Him. Make value judgments every moment of your life.

Is it worth it to break the fast because you're a little hungry and your belly is growling? Because you say, there's only cheese and meat around? Is it really worth it? Is it worth losing that grace? Is it worth sullying your soul? Is it worth judging another person? It's an exchange. Every single thing you do is an exchange. May God help you to have this understanding.

I think *most of my task as a pastor* has been to teach about this exchange, to teach that there are eternal things that matter, and we must live for eternity. The whole world wants to live in the moment, but we must live for eternity.

And when you look for eternity, you do not get satisfaction immediately. It comes slowly, but when it comes, it never ends. This is unlike the world where gratification can come immediately, but then it dissipates, leaving us hungry for more gratification, which then will always dissipate, and we are always hungry; we are always starving. It is better to pursue things that are eternal. This is what this gospel is speaking about.

May God help you to deny yourself. To deny yourself, you have to decide what's essential in life. Your ego, your self-gratification, your comfort, all those things are not important. All that's important is Christ and whether or not there is Christ in you. And the only way to have Christ in you is to be able to make judgments, value judgments, to be able to always think of something as: *Is this worth exchanging for my soul?*

Now, of course, doing one thing or not doing another thing does not obliterate your soul, but I will tell you, you should think of it that way. Every sin is very, very dangerous; because if you sin in a certain way, how do you know that you're going to stop? How do you know that it's not going to affect the rest of your life and bring you far down? You don't know this. The only thing you know is that: If you cleave to God, you will always be safe.

So let's make judgments, moment by moment. Let's always ask this question. Have this question, not in your mind, not something that you think of cognitively; but let it be deeply, deeply in your soul, that you're always making a judgment: Is what I'm about to do or say or more likely think, is that worth doing or saying or thinking, in exchange for my soul? May God help you. Amen.

Transcribed by the hand of Helen, May God save her and her loved ones.

http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/great-lent-sunday-03_2011-03-27+holy-cross+what-shall-a-man-give-in-exchange-for-his-soul_mark8-34-9-1.html

A word from Fr Seraphim

First of all, I would ask your forgiveness that this newsletter is so late. As you know, we are in the middle of Great Lent now, but that's not really an excuse. I'm trying to spend most of the day Tuesday to get this letter out to you. Since I feel bad I am making it a bigger letter, likely, you will only get one newsletter in March, and this is it.

In this newsletter, we have tried to provide you with things that are topical, according to the Great Lent. Of course, some of the articles are for a week that's already past, but hopefully, you will be able to read this newsletter before the Sunday of the Cross, which is March 28, new style.

From my heart, I want to tell you that you must be praying the prayer of St. Ephrem twice a day. Do it with prostrations, or at least with deep bows if you're not able to do prostrations. This is very important.

Also, please be reading the readings of the calendar. We are going through Isaiah, Proverbs, and Genesis. I write many commentaries about these selections. If you are able, also read at least a chapter from the Gospels every single day.

One of you has asked for more stories such as the one in a previous newsletter about blessed Masha the fool who was very simple, but because of love sacrificed herself. I love those stories also. I also love the stories about the Saints. I read them every day, and this newsletter has two retellings of those stories, with commentary. In the future, I will try to find more edifying stories, sometimes even sparing you my commentary!

We try to respond to your request and your questions. If you want to see more of something, we may be able to provide it.

As you know, things are getting a little bit faster now. Things are opening up a little bit, and to be perfectly truthful with you, life is very challenging for father David and me. Each one of us prays for each one of you every day. We beg your prayers also. I believe with all my heart that we are liars if we say we love someone and we do not pray for them regularly.

I want to make one more comment to you. It's one of the most important things that I could ever say to you. I hope you all read the story about blessed Masha. She was clearly very simple, and even mentally retarded. In this temporary life, it was hard to get sensible things out of her, and she did not understand many things. However, she understood love, and after her death, which was because of love, she is no longer impaired in any way. She's more intelligent than all of us put together now. This is the way it is for souls in the next life who are blessed. She also has no sorrow about her previous life. Do you believe this? If you do believe this, then it is worth it to you to increase your labor in this life.

May God bless you and help you in all things. Please pray for the unworthy priest Seraphim.

Forty Martyrs of Amorium, with Theodore, former apostate priest

(03-06-845). These glorious martyrs were all government officials who were put in prison by the Caliph after he conquered the town of Amorium in upper Phrygia. The town was overcome through the treachery of an apostate Christian named Badzites. All the others, save the traitor, were put to death by the sword, including innocent peasants who had sought refuge in the town. The 42 nobles were shut up in the dark prison and given moldy bread infrequently. One of their numbers was authorized to beg for food in the street. They were left in this condition for years, till their clothes rotted off their backs and their bodies were attacked by vermin.

The Caliph promised them their lives if they would only pretend to convert in public prayer. As one man, they refused. They asked the Caliph if he was in their position would he agree to a feigned conversion? He replied, "Certainly because there is nothing more important than liberty!" In this way, the Caliph acted like another Caiaphas in that he unwittingly prophesied the truth. There is nothing more important than Christian liberty, the liberty of the soul, total freedom from the passions and darkness, and God's light illuminating, bringing perfect peace, perfect knowledge, and perfect freedom.

Many people were sent to them to promise them all sorts of fleshly pleasures in this life and the next if only they would pretend to convert to Mohammadism. They consistently refused all blandishments and prayed the Psalter and the services as best they could in the darkness. They were in the state for seven years until they were informed the day before their impending martyrdom by the wretched apostate Badzites.

On the day of their execution, they were brought to the bank of the Euphrates, and a large crowd of Saracens was assembled to watch the bloody spectacle. The officer first summoned Protospatharius Theodore Craterius and proclaimed loudly to everyone that he was a lapsed priest who had become a soldier and had therefore killed many men. The officer urged Theodore to ask for Mohammed's help since he had denied Christ and should therefore expect no hope of mercy from Him. Theodore replied: "On the contrary, precisely because of all of this, I must shed my blood now for Him, that he may forgive my sins!" After a short prayer, he bowed his head and was beheaded, and all the other martyrs followed him in turn with no fear or hesitation.

Let us look at the valiant Theodore, an apostate from his calling, who the heretical Saracens, and perhaps more than a few Christians thought was beyond redemption! Let us not mince words here.

There must have been some terrible reason why Theodore reneged on his priesthood. Doing such a thing would cause massive injury to the soul. He likely became a very worldly man since after offering the unbloody sacrifice, he participated in the bloody killing of enemies as a soldier. He must have been a good soldier because he was rewarded with a high rank. The Protospatharius rank was coveted by all and given to senior generals and provincial governors, and other important dignitaries. They had a seat in the Senate and lived a lavish, opulent lifestyle. We may surmise that Theodore was living in a secular way, and perhaps he felt that he had no possibility of redemption because he had fallen so far, but God's mercy is not only beyond our own but even inconceivable to us. The former fallen priest and secular man Theodore became a luminous martyr, and all of his sins were washed away in a moment.

In our day, it is likely that this scenario of a priest losing his way will happen again, many times. We live in very trying times, and there is a spiritual deadness in our days that is sometimes even among the clergy. There are political intrigue and manipulation, schism and heresy, prowling about like a roaring ravenous lion, trying to devour the church or at least the weak within her. Some will doubtlessly lose their way and fall very far. Perhaps one of those would be me, a poor sinful priest. This is why I pray to the luminous martyr Theodore. There is no sin that we cannot repent from. The pain of martyrdom is only for a moment, but the pain of eternal apostasy is forever.

God will never abandon us, even if we have abandoned hope ourselves. Let us remember that, not only for apostate priests but for anyone that has apostatized in the church or perhaps never known the truth. We all know people that have fallen far, but God's mercy can reach anyone. We should be doing prostrations for those we love who have fallen far, believing that, like Theodore, they can make amends, even if in the last moments of their life.

Holy martyr Theodore, pray to God for us!

The martyrs and many others are listed here:

<http://www.orthodox.net/trebnic/saints-pray-for-us+former-apostates-sinners-secret-christians.docx>

Video about these martyrs: <https://youtu.be/NKV8IUxLd5w> and the same video, also at <https://rumble.com/vetrcd-the-40-martyrs-of-amorium-with-the-former-apostate-priest-theodore-36.html>

St Paul the Simple. We must also be simple.

(Commemorated March 7) Which one of us is simple? We have an unfortunate connotation of simplicity with a lack of intelligence. But God, who knows all things, is simple. If it is possible to do so, we could even consider this to be his primary attribute. This is because the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit are one and three and in perfect agreement and knowledge with one another. God is completely simple. There is nothing in him that opposes himself. We cannot say that about ourselves. We are complex. Sin is complex. There are very few virtues, and one could argue that there is really one virtue - that is love. One cannot say that there are only a few passions or one. There are many, like the head of a Hydra, as a den of snakes.

Simplicity is to be doing only one thing and thinking only one thing, and for a Christian, this would be to have the love of God within our hearts and be doing the Commandments. In practical application, a simple man would

not become irritated, or be lazy, or have bad thoughts about someone. A simple man possesses all of the virtues because his whole being is fixated on the highest virtue, the love of God.

We are in a complex age, and we need simplicity in our personal lives. Even complex and knotty problems are solved only by simplicity. I'm not talking about simplicity and making decisions and understanding information. We need to understand complicated things in our society; however, knowing about them and properly acting based on that knowledge is not possible without simplicity.

Let us look at the life of Paul, the simple and marvel. We're not anything like him, but we can become like him. Do we believe this, or do we think that his life is a fairytale? I believe every word of it. I also believe despite who I am, a wily and complex individual, I can become simple. My sins keep me from this goal, but God is merciful Beyond any Mercy that I

can understand or comprehend. I've added Paul the simple to my list of saints that I ask for help every day. Perhaps, after hearing his amazing life, you will also.

Paul was a farmer in Egypt at the time of Saint Anthony the Great. He was a married man, and his wife was unfaithful to him. One day Paul came back to the house and caught her in the very Act. He was not angry common, or did he curse or swear at her. He just laughed a little and said, "well, that's nothing. By Jesus, I won't take her back. Go and take care of her and the children. As for me, I'm off to be a monk."

Paul went to the door of Anthony and begged him to be a monk. Anthony, seeing a 60-year-old man in front of him, told him that he was not ready for the rigors of his life and shut the door on him. Saint Paul said to him that he wanted to die there. Saint Anthony did not open the door for three days, and Paul stood in the exact spot where he addressed Anthony and did not eat or drink for three days. Perhaps one would say that Anthony was cruel. That would be an opinion of a complex person. I think, although the story does not tell of it, that Anthony saw something in Paul and wanted to test him.

After the three days, Anthony took Paul in and had Paul fully participated in the strictness of his life. We in the world who can eat anytime we want and sleep on a soft bed, and have air conditioning that we run when the temperature outside is slightly elevated, have no idea of the rigors of life in the Egyptian desert where water was a scarce commodity in which they had to walk sometimes more than a mile to retrieve.

Paul participated in all matters of Anthony's life without complaint or murmuring. Anthony taught him to plate ropes with Palm leaves that have been soaked in water. This work is arduous and time-consuming and tears the hands. After Paul had finished some ropes, Anthony pretended that they were not suitable and told him to undo it and do it again. He did this without complaint. This is simplicity in action! Which one of us would have begun to do our work again without any complaint? Without a frown, or a sigh, or an irritated internal thought? We, in our complexity, think of great works as raising the dead and healing the sick, and casting out demons when the greatest work is when a man has mastery over his own soul and is simple.

Paul cared only about one thing; he wanted to be a monk. The reason for his desire was because he wanted to be only with God. Therefore, he, with simplicity, endured any obstacle in his life.

Anthony fasted in an extreme way as did Paul right alongside him. After several days of fasting Anthony put out some bread and said shall we have some bread. Paul in his simplicity, because simplicity is also obedience, said to Anthony, "Abba if you take a piece of bread then I will have some too." So, they ate a loaf of bread. Anthony put out more bread and asked if Paul wanted more bread and Paul again repeated, "if you have some bread Abba, I will have some too." Anthony said to him that he was a monk and one loaf with sufficient for him. Paul, not yet a monk, did not claim to be a monk, so he said in his simplicity, "I want to be a monk so one is sufficient for me also."

After many other tests, Anthony established Paul in a cell some distance from his own. Paul became holy and known for his prayer, especially for the casting out of demons. One day a man possessed with a terrifying demon was taken to Anthony for exorcism, but Anthony said that he had not the power to cast out this demon. He told those bringing the man that this was Paul's business. The man was brought to Paul, and Paul in his simplicity, but with boldness, told the demon to leave the man by the prayers of his Elder. The demon did not leave and through the mouth of the man began insulting Paul and Anthony. This would seem to be a difficult problem that had bested the simple Paul, but with simplicity comes strength and courage, and endurance. Paul merely went out to a rock in the middle of the day that was not shaded and prayed. He declared that he would not move from this rock until the demon came out of the man.

And so, the demon did, crying out against his will that he had been Mastered by Paul simplicity.

What are we to glean from the stories of Paul the simple? We should not go out into the desert or stand on a rock on a hot day and make a declaration to God that we would not move until such and such happens. We can in some way be a little bit simpler weekend have Hazard goal of each day that we just love, and that we just follow the Commandments. Perhaps a good way to be simple is to measure our words and not say them unless we have thought about them first. This, of course, also applies to words that we type on our keyboards or our telephones.

If we have even a bit of simplicity in us, we will be amazed by the life of Saint Paul and will be energized by it. We will not fall into despair thinking we cannot come anywhere close to his exploits. That is not the point of reading his life or reading the lives of any of the Saints. We are Unworthy of even the ground on which we walk! And yet God loves us Beyond any love that we can understand, but we are called to understand this love. Through the prayers of our Holy Father Paul the simple, Lord Jesus Christ save us!

YouTube: <https://youtu.be/RPhWCEVwa5c>

Reproof will save us, even if it is unjust.

He who will not accept a reproof, just or unjust, renounces his own salvation. But he who accepts it with an effort, or even without an effort, will soon receive the remission of his sins. The Ladder of Divine Ascent, St. John Climacus, step 4:44, Obedience

Can you see my brother or sister, how different Christianity is from the ways of the world? In the world, no one will accept a reproof that they consider to be unjust. Many will not even receive a just reproof because they are blinded by pride. Or perhaps they will accept it if given in a certain way so as not to embarrass them or put them on the spot.

The Christian way of life is to accept any reproof! It doesn't matter if the proof is unjust or just, or if it is true or false! Can we imagine how beautiful this way of life is! How amazing it would be for a person never to be unsettled in their soul no matter what is done to them or what is said to them!

In the lives of the Saints, we have several examples of women who pretended to be male monastics and were accused of fathering a child. Theodora of Alexandria (09-11) was a married woman who fell into adultery. She was so ashamed of her sin that she dressed as a man and went to a monastery, passing herself off as Theodore and asked to be admitted as a novice. This was in an age when there were eunuchs, so her lack of a beard was not suspicious. She lived an exemplary life as an apparent male monastic, but her repentance and goodness angered the devil. Some jealous monks accused Theodore of having fathered a child with a woman of the nearby village. She accepted the false reproof! She was cast out of the monastery and, as the apparently fallen monk

Theodore, raised the son for seven years until she was allowed to return to the monastery with the child before bringing him to the monastery because the fathers relented and allowed her to come. Only at her death was it revealed that she was a woman.

Can we imagine doing this ourselves? We would have immediately denied that we fathered that child, but what would have happened to the child? The saint accepted the false reproof because of love for the child, and not because she knew the child, but because the child is a human being, made in the image of God, and would have suffered if no one took care of him.

We must read the writings of the Holy Saints with discretion. This advice does not mean that every single falsehood should go unchallenged: by no means. However, if we are accused falsely, we should feel no more movement in our soul than if we were praised. This is not just for monastics; It is the Christian Evangelical way of life.

The person who is continually praised is in danger of Hellfire. Our character cannot bear continual praise. On the other hand, a person who understands the Evangelical gospel and pulls it to his bosom cannot be hurt by derision.

Because I do prison ministry, I thought of my brothers and sisters in prison when I read these words St John Climacus. I live in the world, and for the most part, people treat me with decency. There is generally basic respect even among strangers. It is not always this way in prison! On a daily basis, there is derision, inconvenience, unfairness, and usually no recourse whatsoever for the inmate. A Christian prisoner will accept derision from the guards without having a passionate movement in their soul.

Do you think that this is impossible? If you do, then you do not understand the gospel, and you do not know what baptism does to a person or the purpose of life. It is challenging and even onerous and bitter, to accept the pettiness and the dishonesty and even the guards' cruelty. But if you can accept it even a little bit, your path to heaven is sure.

http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/ladder-of-divine-ascent-04-44_2101+obedience-and-reproof.doc

Withdrawing from the World, as we are journeying towards God.

How does a person with responsibilities in the world withdraw from it?

"All who have willingly left the things of the world have certainly done so either for the sake of the future Kingdom, or because of the multitude of their sins, or for love of God. If they were not moved by any of these reasons, their withdrawal from the world was unreasonable." (The Ladder of Divine Ascent, by St John Climacus, Step 01:5)

I am not a monk. I minister to those who are not monks. Saint John was writing to Monks, but perhaps even in his wisdom, he did not understand that his book would be used by Christians throughout the centuries regardless of whether they were in the monastic life or not.

For laypeople (and for all people), withdrawing from the world must start with a knowledge of who they are and who they are becoming. They must know their purpose, and they must understand that their purpose is not in any way different from that of the holiest hermits and monastics. We are called in this temporal life to become eternal and perfected beings. Nothing else matters in this life.

If we are attached to anything in this life besides God, then, to the extent that we are attached, we are not in any tangible way withdrawing from the world. If we are struggling against our attachments, then God in His mercy will see our feeble struggles and will be assisting us in withdrawing from the world.

Withdrawal from the world is not just to flee from things that are considered worldly; it is a journey *towards* God. Perhaps we should not say "withdrawal from the world" as much as we should say a "journey to God" and to the fulfillment of our purpose, the entire reason why we were created. When we are on an important journey, we are anxious to meet our destination and not let anything not related to the journey distract us.

Withdrawal from the world also means that we learn not to value the things of the flesh. Pleasures of the flesh are not sinful unless we covet them. If we want comfort or money and are not willing to give to the poor

or our parish because we want to save the money for our old age, we are not withdrawing from the world, and indeed our hearts are very small.

How do we learn not to covet the things of the world, the comforts of the world, our money, and our entertainments? We learn by experiencing God. Our heartfelt desire every day should be that we experience God, and our lamentation should be that our passions and the darkness in our heart make it difficult, and on some days, so distant from us as to be almost invisible. The Apostle teaches that we see through a glass darkly, and the reason the images are indistinct is because of our passions. Do we believe this?

Every Great Lent, and indeed every day, but despite our weakness and intransigence, let us at least every Great Lent decide to be more generous and less miserly. Let us choose to give more of our funds and of our hearts to others.

Holy Isaiah said, we are people of unclean lips, and we live among people of unclean lips, so how dare we believe that we, dragging all of our sins with us, can be withdrawing from the world? We must believe this. We must attempt this! We must succeed in this! God will take the feeblest effort and magnify it. We are not responsible for being competent. We are accountable for our effort, and God provides the competence.

The scripture tells us that, "A man shall draw nigh and the heart is deep, and God shall be exalted." (Ps 63:6b-7a) We all have a deep heart, so deep that it can contain all of the Uncontainable God and all of our neighbors. Let us begin or continue to withdraw from the world by adding

more of God and more of our neighbors to our hearts. Let us open our eyes and see that among us are those that have needs. They are in our family and our place of work, in our parish, and everywhere. We might be aware of them because of personal contact or email or social media correspondence, or news reports. Whoever they are, if they have come to our heart, we must not cast them out. We must retain them in our hearts; this is withdrawing from the world because retaining people in our hearts is happening because of the journey towards God.

This is especially the way that a layperson must withdraw from the world. A monk also does this because this is the life of any Christian, but he also performs ascetical feats that we are unable to perform. Regardless of what ascetic feats we can perform, we all are able to add people to our hearts and keep them there.

We must pray every day in our closet. We must pray with our blood, with our sweat, and with tears if we are able to have them. We must pray for those people that are in our hearts; we must feel their need and even the crisis that is in their life. We are all in crisis. If we do not think that we are in crisis and that sin is banging at the door and that the lion is roaring about and could devour us, we are too attached to the world to see spiritual things right before our eyes.

Christian! Withdraw from the world! Withdraw by journeying towards God. If you cannot wholly withdraw, then do what you are able to do! You are able to do more than you think you can do. You are able to have time in prayer in the evening or the morning without distraction. You are able to do more than say a few prayers from the prayer book, but also to do prostrations for your loved ones and for those who have needs, and for everyone who is in your heart. You are able to ask the prayers of various saints that are also in your heart. You are able to say the Prayer of Saint Ephrem with effort and with longing.

Perhaps someone will protest to me and say, "I cannot do prostrations because of my back or because of a medical condition or because I am out of shape." Don't listen to those excuses! If you cannot physically do a prostration by going down to the floor and coming back up, do a deep bow. If you cannot do a deep bow, then make the sign of the

cross and reproach yourself and pray for your loved ones and everyone in your heart.

Do not let your bodily infirmities or perhaps your bodily laziness keep you from praying with your heart. Do not let that great lie of Satan, that we do not have enough time or that our required duties make it impossible to pray with intensity and with our heart every day, keep you from praying with your heart! You are able to do much more than you think you can do! You must try to do a little bit more, and God will magnify this effort, and then you will be able to do much more.

If you must rise early to go to work or because the children arise early in the morning, get up a little earlier! Perhaps you can stay up a little bit later and say your prayers when the household is quiet. Perhaps, if God makes you arise at midnight or 2 in the morning, you can stay up for a little while, and you can pray, if not with prostrations, then at least with zeal. You can pray the Jesus prayer or chant the psalter. Perhaps you will fall asleep when you are doing this, and that will be a blessed sleep, and God will give you the bodily rest you require.

Saint John tells us in the short quotation that there are unreasonable reasons to withdraw from the world. What is your reason for prayer? Is it because of habit, or is it because you think this is required of you? Do you come to church because it is the expected thing to do? Do you give alms with one hand held out and the other one grasping your arm and trying to pull it back to your bosom? The only reason to give alms, and fast, and to pray with prostrations and tears and to have a set prayer rule and all of the rest is because God is greater than everything in the world, and everything in the world will go away. Only what we become because of our efforts and God's grace and our prayer and our tears will endure. Do you believe this? If you do, then find a way to be more ascetical this great let. Get up 15 minutes earlier, go to bed 15 minutes later, or when you need to go to the bathroom at 2 in the morning, stay up for a little bit and pray. God will reward you. The reward will be beyond all of your expectations.

http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/ladder-of-divine-ascent-01-05_2021+withdrawing-from-the-world.pdf

Do we pay attention when we pray?

"Noticing that one of the brothers stood during the psalm-singing with more heartfelt feeling than many of the others and that his movements and the changes of his face made it look as though he was talking to someone, especially at the beginning of the hymns, I asked him to explain what this habit of the blessed man meant. And knowing that it was for my benefit not to hide it, he told me: 'I have the habit, Father John, at the very beginning, of collecting my thoughts, my mind, and my soul, and summoning them, I cry to them: O come, let us worship and fall down before Christ, our King, and God.'" The Ladder of Divine Ascent by St John Climacus, step 04:38, Obedience

We say the prayer "O come let us worship Christ our God" many times in our services. It is at the beginning of almost any prayer rule. What are we doing we are saying this prayer? One person is reading it, and we are all making the sign of the cross and doing a bow with each one of the three verses of the hymn, but what else are we doing?

This blessed man shows us what we should be doing. We should be summoning all of our energies to worship God. How many times have we said this prayer, but it would not have mattered if it was the prayer or some names in the phone book? We must learn to pray with attention.

Even our simplest and most common prayers are full of deep theological meaning, and they are life. Are we more alive when we say them? Perhaps we can amend ourselves, and when we hear this prayer, we can take it as a call to all of the members of our body and our soul to be attentive because we are addressing our creator and God, and we will get better.

http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/ladder-of-divine-ascent-04-38_2021+o-come-let-us-worship+attentiveness-in-prayer.doc

The Old man, Menas.

As the Lord did not wish to deprive me of the prayer of a holy father in the same monastery, a week before my departure He took to Himself a wonderful man called Menas who occupied the second place after the superior, and had lived 59 years in the community fulfilling all the various offices. On the 3rd day after the falling asleep of this holy man, when we had performed the customary rites over him, suddenly the whole place where the saint was resting was filled with fragrance. Then the great man allowed us to uncover the coffin in which he had been placed, and when this was done we all saw that fragrant myrrh was flowing like two fountains from his precious feet. Then that teacher said to all: 'Look! The sweat of his toils and labours have been offered as myrrh to God and truly accepted.'

The fathers of that place told us of many triumphs of this most saintly Menas, and amongst others the following: 'Once the superior wanted to test his God-given patience: In the evening Menas came to the abbot's cell,

and having prostrated before the abbot, asked him as usual to give him instruction. But the abbot left him lying on the ground till the hour of the Office, and only then blessed him; and having rebuked him for being fond of self-display and for being impatient, he ordered him to get up. The holy man knew Menas would bear all this courageously, and therefore he made this scene for the edification of all.' A disciple of Saint Menas confirmed what was told us about his director, and added: 'I was inquisitive to know whether sleep overcame him while he lay prostrate before the abbot. But he assured me that while lying on the ground he had recited by heart the whole psalter.' The Ladder of Divine Ascent, St. John Climacus, step 4:34, Obedience

About Isidore

A certain man called Isidore, of magistrate's rank, from the city of Alexandria, had recently renounced the world in the above-mentioned monastery, and I found him still there. That most holy shepherd, after accepting him, found that he was full of mischief, very cruel, sly, fierce and arrogant. But with human ingenuity that most wise man contrived to outwit the cunning of the devils, and said to Isidore: 'If you have decided to take upon yourself the yoke of Christ, then I want you first of all to learn obedience.' Isidore replied: 'As iron to the smith, so I surrender myself in submission to you, Holy Father.' The great father, making use of this comparison, at once gave exercise to the iron Isidore, and said: 'I want you, brother by nature, to stand at the gate of the monastery, and to make a prostration to everyone coming in or going out, and to say: "Pray for me, father; I am an epileptic." 'And he obeyed as an angel obeys the Lord. When he had spent 7 years there, he attained to deep humility and compunction. Then the glorious father, after the lawful 7 years and the man's incomparable patience, judged him fully worthy to be numbered among the brethren and wanted to profess him and have him ordained. But Isidore through others and through my feeble intervention, implored the shepherd many times to let him finish his course as he was living before, vaguely hinting that his end and call were drawing near. And that

was actually the case. For when his director had allowed him to remain as he was, 10 days later in his lowliness he passed gloriously to the Lord.

And on the 7th day after his own falling asleep, the porter of the monastery was also taken . For the blessed man had said to him: 'If I have found favour in the sight of the Lord, in a short time you also will be inseparably joined to me there.' And that is what happened, in witness of his unashamed obedience and divine humility. 24. When he was still living, I asked this great Isidore what occupation his mind had found during his time at the gate. And the famous ascetic did not hide this from me, wishing to help me: 'In the beginning', he said, 'I judged that I had been sold into slavery for my sins; and so it was with bitterness , with a great effort, and as it were with blood that I made the prostration. But after a year had passed , my heart no longer felt sorrow, and I expected a reward for my obedience from God Himself. But when another year had gone by, I began to be deeply conscious of my unworthiness even to live in the monastery, and see and meet the fathers, and partake of the Divine Mysteries. And I did not dare to look anyone in the face, but bending low with my eyes, and still lower with my thought, I sincerely asked for the prayers of those coming in and going out.' The Ladder of Divine Ascent, St. John Climacus, step 4:23, Obedience

A Drunkard Monk

We share this story to edify you and teach us to refrain from judging people based upon appearances. By no means should your take-home from this very edifying story, told by a saint, be that it's okay to get drunk. Everyone has a different battle in life. Almost universally, all of us have the battle not to make excuses for ourselves. Don't let this story be a way to make excuses. So, no, you shouldn't be drinking the raisin jack! I think an excellent rule of thumb for you and me to live by, based upon this story, is that things are seldom as they appear to be. We should therefore refrain from judgment until all doubt is removed. This rule works very well not only to keep us from judging others but also to keep from judging ourselves and becoming despondent. (Priest Seraphim)

There was a monk on Mount Athos who lived in Karyes. He would drink every day and then cause problems for pilgrims.

When he died, a group of them hurried to St Paisios the Athonite as they were happy to tell him that the problem was now over.

It turned out that St Paisius already knew about the monk's death and had seen hosts of Angels come to meet the monk's soul.

The pilgrims got perplexed and even annoyed.

St Paisios told them the following:

This monk was born in Asia Minor, shortly before the Holocaust. His parents did not want to leave their child on his own, so they would take him with them to harvest. Lest the boy cry and they be caught, they would

add some strong alcoholic drink to the milk to make him fall asleep.

Because of this, he became addicted to alcohol. Doctors advised him against starting a family, so he arrived at Mount Athos and became a monk. He confessed to an elder that he was a drunkard. The elder instructed him to make prostrations every day and pray to the Most Holy Theotokos asking her to help him gradually reduce drinking. After a year of continuing struggle and repentance, he managed to reduce his daily 20 drinks to 19. The struggle continued, and after all those years of his spiritual warfare, the monk would now have only 2-3 drinks a day.

For years, people knew him as a drunkard monk and a troublemaker, but God saw a warrior fighting with great zeal to overcome his passion.

Every Heart Has Its Own World

A Parable.

An old man was sitting by the city gates. A traveler came up to him and said, "I have never been in this city before. Please tell me what kind of people live here."

"What kind of people live in the city that you came here from?" the old man asked another question.

"They were angry and selfish people, and I left them without regret."

"The people you will meet here are the same," replied the old man.

Sometime later, another traveler asked the old man the same question: "Tell me what kind of people live in this city? I have just arrived and don't know the local customs."

The old man again replied with his usual question: "And what kind of people live in the city you arrived from?"

"They were wonderful people, kind and hospitable. Many became my friends and it was not easy for me to leave them," was the answer.

"The people you will meet here are the same," replied the old man.

Bewildered by the two conversations, a merchant asked the old man: "How can it be? You gave two completely different answers to the same question..."

The old man explained: "Everyone has their own world in their hearts. If someone didn't find anything good where they came from, they will not find it here either. And if they had friends elsewhere, they will make friends here too. For we see in the people around us what we have inside us."

This wonderful parable teaches us the main thing - the world we have around us depends on the world we have inside us.

If there is resentment, anger, and a desire to fight inside us, then we will definitely meet rivals. If we radiate joy, light, and friendliness, then we will definitely meet nice people and make friends with them. Life sees us as what we are inside, and not as what we want to appear to others.

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NB (Nota Bena – "Note Well")

"It is best to live simply. Do not wrack your brain. Pray to God. The Lord will arrange everything, just live more simply. Do not agonize over how and what to do; let things take their course.

That is what it means to live simply." + Saint Ambrose of Optina

Saint Porphyrios on antichrist, the mark of the beast, and 666:

"The Elder asked me: "Tell me, my child, what did Elder Aimilianos say about 666 and the Antichrist?"

I told him: "He told us in a gathering a few days ago to not worry. We should be interested in having a vibrant relationship with Christ and not give much attention to the Antichrist, because then he will become the center of our lives and not Christ."

Immediately the Elder hit his hands against his bed and said: "What did you say, my child, what did you say?! Glory to You, O God, that I found a spiritual father who agrees with me! My child, these spiritual fathers here in the world, what have they done?! They have upset souls and created many problems psychologically and with families with the 666. People in the world cannot sleep and are taking psychiatric drugs and sleeping pills in order to sleep. What is this thing? Christ does not want these things, my child. And can I tell you something?"

"What Elder?" I said. He told me: "For us Christians, when we experience Christ there is no Antichrist. Tell me something, on this bed I sit here, can you also sit on it?" I said to him: "No, Elder." He asked: "Why?" I responded: "Because if I sit on you I will crush you." He asked again: "Will you never be able to sit here?" I said to him: "When you leave, Elder, I can sit."

He said to me: "Precisely, my child. The same happens with our souls. When we have Christ inside us, can the Antichrist come? Can anything opposite this enter our souls? For this reason, my child, today we do not have Christ within us and because of this we worry about the Antichrist."

When Christ is within us, everything becomes Paradise. Christ is everything, my child, and the Opposer we should not fear; this you should always tell people. And let me tell you something. If the same Antichrist came now with a device that shot laser beams and sealed me by force with 666, I would not be upset. You will tell me, 'Elder, is this not the seal of the Antichrist?' Yes, but even if he wrote 666 on me a thousand times with laser beams, indelibly, I would not be upset.

Why? Because, my child, the first martyrs they cast to the wild beasts, and when they did their cross the wild beasts became like lambs. They cast them in the sea, but when they did their cross the sea became like dry land and they walked on it. They cast them in the fire, but when they did their cross the fire was cooled. My blessed child, what have we become today? Do we believe in Christ? In our cross? Why did Christ come? Didn't Christ come to strengthen us in our weaknesses?

This is what you should say to the Elder, my child. And you should tell the people to not fear the Antichrist. We are children of Christ, we are children of the Church." All this made quite an impression on me."

Source: Ανθολόγιο Συμβουλών Γέροντος Πορφυρίου, σελ. 71, 72-75, δ' έκδ. 2003. Translated by John Sanidopoulos. Accessed from: <https://www.johnsanidopoulos.com/2011/01/elder-porphyrios-we-ought-not-to-fear.html>

Above all, do not lie to yourself!

"Above all, do not lie to yourself. A man who lies to himself and listens to his own lie comes to a point where he does not discern any truth either in himself or anywhere around him, and thus falls into disrespect towards himself and others. Not respecting anyone, he ceases to love, and having no love, he gives himself up to the passions and coarse pleasures, in order to occupy and amuse himself, and in his vices reaches complete bestiality, and it all comes from lying continually to others and to himself." (The Brothers Karamazov, Fyodor Dostoevsky)

Answers to Questions about the Sunday of the Cross

ANSWER 1.

IN THE prophet Ezekiel (9:6) it is said that when the Angel of the Lord was sent to punish and destroy the sinning people, it was told him not to strike those on whom the "mark" had been made. In the original text this mark is called "tau," the Hebrew letter corresponding to the letter "T.," which is how in ancient times the cross was made, which then was an instrument of punishment.

Moses, who held his arms raised in the form of a cross during the battle, gave victory to the Israelites over the Amalekites. He also, dividing the Red Sea by a blow of his rod and by a transverse blow uniting the waters again, saved Israel from Pharaoh, who drowned in the water, while Israel crossed over on the dry bottom (Exodus, chs. 14, 17).

Elisha brought a child back to life again by stretching upon him in the form of a cross: And when Elisha was come into the house, behold, the

child was dead, and laid upon his bed. {33} He went in therefore, and shut the door upon them twain, and prayed unto the LORD. {34} And he went up, and lay upon the child, and put his mouth upon his mouth, and his eyes upon his eyes, and his hands upon his hands: and he stretched himself upon the child; and the flesh of the child waxed warm. {35} Then he returned, and walked in the house to and fro; and went up, and stretched himself upon him: and the child sneezed seven times, and the child opened his eyes. (2 Ki 4:32-35)

ANSWER 2

And Jesus answered them, saying, The hour is come, that the Son of man should be glorified. {24} Verily, verily, I say unto you, Except a corn of wheat fall into the ground and die, it abideth alone: but if it die, it bringeth forth much fruit. {25} He that loveth his life shall lose it; and he that hateth his life in this world shall keep it unto life eternal. {26} If any man serve me, let him follow me; and where I am, there shall also my servant be: if any man serve me, him will my Father honor. {27} Now is my soul troubled; and what shall I say? Father, save me from this hour: but for this cause came I unto this hour. {28} Father, glorify thy name. Then came there a voice from heaven, saying, I have both glorified it, and will glorify it again. {29} The people therefore, that stood by, and heard it, said that it thundered: others said, An angel spake to him. {30} Jesus answered and said, This voice came not because of me, but for your sakes. {31} Now is the judgment of this world: now shall the prince of this world be cast out. {32} And I, if I be lifted up from the earth, will draw all men unto me. {33} This he said, signifying what death he should die. (John 12:23-33)

Jesus said to Peter, after his three-fold restoration: Verily, verily, I say unto thee, When thou wast young, thou girdedst thyself, and walkedst whither thou wouldest: but when thou shalt be old, thou shalt stretch forth thy hands, and another shall gird thee, and carry thee whither thou wouldest not. {19} This spake he, signifying by what death he should glorify God. And when he had spoken this, he saith unto him, Follow me. (John 21:18-19)

ANSWER 3

The Romans used crucifixion as a punishment for slaves and the worst criminals. It was a punishment designed to invoke terror, because of it's extreme pain, and the way it displayed the dying man for all to see in his death agonies. No Roman citizen was ever crucified.

ANSWER 4

Now there stood by the cross of Jesus his mother, and his mother's sister, Mary the wife of Cleophas, and Mary Magdalene. {26} When Jesus therefore saw his mother, and the disciple standing by, whom he loved, he saith unto his mother, Woman, behold thy son! {27} Then saith he to the disciple, Behold thy mother! And from that hour that disciple took her unto his own home. (John 19:25-27)

ANSWER 5

Christians do not prostrate on Sunday because this is the day we always celebrate the Resurrection, and we recall how God is able to make us stand. Our standing reminds us of the resurrection. There are one or two Sundays a year when we do prostrate (the Third Sunday of Great Lent, and the Exaltation of the Holy Cross, if it falls on a Sunday. On this day, the hymn "Before Thy cross," which we sing while prostration, teaches us what our prostrations mean:

Before Thy Cross, / we fall down in worship, O Master, / and Thy holy Resurrection / we glorify.

When we prostrate, it is in worship of the Risen Lord, and when we raise ourselves up, we recall the resurrection.

A Christian prostrates when he makes the sign of the cross, and falls to his hands and knees (it is usually easier to have the hands touch the floor a moment before the knees), and bows his head to the ground, then gets back up.

ANSWER 6

The cross is the sign of victory. The mind of the church also knows this symbol as an effective prayer for all circumstances, if it is made with faith. There are innumerable examples of the deliverance from Christians from every kind of danger, merely when they made the sign of the cross with faith.

The sign of the cross is made by placing the thumb and first 2 fingers of the right hand together in a point, which symbolizes the Holy Trinity, with the other two fingers against the palm, which symbolizes the two natures of Christ, and touching the forehead, then the breast, then the right and left shoulders.

There is another Orthodox rite, called "Old Believer," or "Old Rite," where the fingers are held differently, but the meaning is the same.

ANSWER 7

St Helen, mother of St Constantine, discovered the Holy and Precious cross during excavations in Jerusalem, in the 4th century. The cross was found lying with the other crosses, from the thieves that had been crucified on each side of Christ. The true cross was identified when a dead man was raised back to life again after the cross was touched to him.

ANSWER 8

We sing the troparion of the cross every Wednesday and Friday. On Wednesday, Christ was betrayed (sold), and on Friday He was crucified.

Most Sunday matins services, among the canons we sing is the "Canon to the Cross and Resurrection."

On Fridays, instead of a Theotokion in some places of the services, we sing a "StavroTheotokion," which is a hymn about the Theotokos and the Holy Cross.

We make the sign of the cross innumerable times, during our daily life, for every circumstance.

ANSWER 9

3rd Sunday of Great Lent

Exaltation of the Precious and Life-giving cross (Sep 14)

Procession of the Holy cross (Aug 1)

ANSWER 10

In general, whenever one venerates an icon, or the Holy Gospel, or the Holy Cross in the center of the church, he makes two bows or prostrations, while making the sign of the cross. He then kisses the holy object on the icon stand, turns to the priest and receives a blessing, and returns back in front of the icon stand and does another bow or prostration.

2 bows, get a blessing, another bow

When two people venerate, they do everything together. The eldest gets a blessing first, and returns to the front of the icon stand, and waits for his partner. When they both are back in front of the icon stand, they do their final bow or prostration together.

On the Sunday of the Holy cross, prostrations are done in front of the Cross.

ANSWER 11.

When we make the sign of the cross on ourselves, the three fingers together represent the Holy Trinity, and the two fingers folded into the palm of the hand represent the two natures of Jesus Christ – God and man. We fold them into the palm to recall the Incarnation, when God became

man and came down from heaven.

The priest's fingers spell out the first and last letters of the name "Jesus Christ" (**I**HCOY**C**) (**X**PICTO**C**). We read the acronym starting from the index finger. It is easiest to envision the letters if we are looking at the back of the hand and reading left to right. The index finger looks like "iota" (I). The ring finger is bent to look like "C." The thumb and 4th finger form an "X." The little finger is also bent to look like a "C"

It is by the name of Jesus that we are saved and receive blessings: *"At the name of Jesus every knee should bow, of things in heaven, and things in earth, and things under the earth"*

¹ "By the Waters of Babylon" is the entire Psalm 136, sung to a plaintive melody, after the Polyelos Psalm during Matins. It is only sung in church the three Sundays that precede Great Lent, Sunday of the Prodigal Son, The Last Judgment (Meatfare) and Forgiveness (Cheesefare) It is significant that this same hymn is chanted at the beginning of the service of monastic tonsure.

² This homily was written in 1965, when the church in Russia was still under captivity to the Communist regime.

³ Great Lent and Holy Week, including Holy Saturday is 36 days, and therefore encompasses **almost exactly a tenth** of the days of the year, and many spiritual writers have commented on this. Here is the math:

- Great Lent is 6 weeks long, and Saturday and Sunday are not rigorous fasting days. Counting only weekdays, this gives us 6 weeks of 5 days each = 30 days.
- Holy Week is also a week of fasting, so this adds another 5 days. We are now at 35 days.
- Since Holy Saturday is considered to be a fast day (we can have wine, but not oil), we add another day, giving us 36 days.
- $36/365 = 9.8$ percent, or, rounded up, 10%, a tithe of the year.

⁴ "For the grace of God that bringeth salvation hath appeared to all men, (12) Teaching us that, denying ungodliness and worldly lusts, we should live soberly, righteously, and godly, in this present world; (13) Looking for that blessed hope, and the glorious appearing of the great God and our Savior Jesus Christ; (14) Who gave himself for us, that he might redeem us from all iniquity, and purify unto himself a peculiar people, zealous of good works." Titus 2:11-14 KJV

⁵ "And Nathanael said unto him, Can there any good thing come out of Nazareth? Philip saith unto him, Come and see." (John 1:46).

This is from the story of Jesus calling Philip and Nathaniel as his disciples, read on the Sunday of Orthodoxy. Our entire life should be spent answering this question! "Nazareth" is not just a place, but mystically represents the human heart. The question whose answer we must pursue is "Can we become completely good and perfected?" This is a dogma of the church, but no dogma is powerful and salvific to the individual unless it is believed and lived.

⁶ We bought our land several years before we built on it, and in those long years, we prayed a weekly Moleben (prayer service) before a large Cedar cross we erected. After we built our temple we move the cross to the front. It is our custom to always prostrate before this cross at the end of the liturgy when we are celebrating the holy cross.

⁷ A "doxology" is a hymn of praise to God. The "Great Doxology" is at the end of all matins services and in a festive matins service it is sung.

⁸ This Troparion is in any good complete prayer book and is sung every Wednesday. It is: "O Lord, save Thy people, and bless Thine inheritance; grant Thou unto Orthodox Christians victory over enemies; and by the power of the Cross Do Thou preserve Thy commonwealth."

⁹ This short homily is in audio and text form here:

http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/great-lent-sunday-03_2011-03-26+holy-cross+before-thy-cross-we-bow-down-and-worship.mp3

http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/great-lent-sunday-03_2011-03-26+holy-cross+before-thy-cross-we-bow-down-and-worship.doc

http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/great-lent-sunday-03_2011-03-26+holy-cross+before-thy-cross-we-bow-down-and-worship.pdf

http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/great-lent-sunday-03_2011-03-26+holy-cross+before-thy-cross-we-bow-down-and-worship.html

¹⁰ The Paschal Troparion is: "Christ is risen from the dead, trampling down death by death, and upon those in the tombs bestowing life." It is sung in many different melodies, and usually many different languages during Pascha, and all throughout the Paschal period, which ends liturgically the day before the commemoration of the ascension of our Lord Jesus Christ, which was 40 days after Pascha.

¹¹ Those who attend long services know how useful they are to the soul. We are so noisy in our souls that it is very difficult to pray without distraction, especially immediately upon entering the church. It often takes a lot of time before our souls are in a soft and receptive state. In my experience, this often occurs at the end of long services. Of course, many people think of long services as difficult and onerous. When a person gets past the difficulty and the fatigue, wonderful things happen.

¹² A sticheron (singular, Stichera is the plural) is a short hymn, meant to be sung. They appear in almost all of our services, multiple times. This is a Greek word, which, and common practice this is just transliterated and never translated.

¹³ John 12:32: "And I, if I be lifted up from the earth, will draw all men unto me."

¹⁴ The prayer of St. Ephrem is said many times, every weekday during Great Lent. For the prayer, and an explanation, see: <http://www.orthodox.net/greatlent/o-lord-and-master-of-my-life-prayer-of-st-ephrem-01.html>. It is also in [DOC](#) or [PDF format](#).

¹⁵ Luke 17:21: "Neither shall they say, Lo here! or, lo there! for, behold, the kingdom of God is within you."

¹⁶ This is the final exclamation, said by the priest, which ends Vespers during a vigil service. Immediately following this exclamation, the reader begins to read the "Six Psalms."

¹⁷ A homily given by Priest Seraphim Holland (seraphim@orthodox.net), during Liturgy for the Veneration of the Precious Cross, Great Lent, 2018. You may quote for this, as long as you give attribution, and the URL.

¹⁸ The Ladder of Divine Ascent, Step 8.8

¹⁹ Hebrews 4: 15 "For we have not an high priest which cannot be touched with the feeling of our infirmities; but was in all points tempted like as we are, yet without sin."

²⁰ Hebrews 14: 16

²¹ Cf. Romans 14:4 Who art thou that judgest another man's servant? to his own master he standeth or falleth. Yea, he shall be holden up: for God is able to make him stand.